

ONE AGAINST THE DIMMING



A SOULLESS SAGA

BY ABDULLAH ASHIQ AND ASHIQ ALIBHAI

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Chapter 1: The Normal Ghost

The ghost didn't know it was being hunted.

Khalid watched it from the third floor of what used to be a pharmacy. He crouched behind the lip of a collapsed wall, perfectly still. Below, the thing drifted through the road in slow, stupid circles, the way Normal ghosts always did when they had nothing to chase.

It looked, from this distance, almost like a person. Almost. The neck looked too long. The knees and elbows bent the wrong way.

He learned early on not to look too hard at their faces.

He checked his kit. Salt bomb in his left hand, made from an old soap dispenser. Iron shavings in a leather pouch on his belt. The limestone circle was already drawn on the cracked asphalt below, thirty minutes ago, while the ghost was on the other side of the block. Wide enough.

He'd done this a hundred times.

He dropped silently from the third floor onto the second-floor fire escape, then from the fire escape to the street. He landed in a roll that brought him up on one knee, salt bomb in his hand. The ghost turned at the sound. He needed it moving toward the circle, not away from it.

"Come on then," he said.

It came.

They always came when you talked. Something about the sound of a living voice pulled at them. Not hunger, not exactly, but some kind of horrible magnetic effect. It drifted toward him, and sped up. The closer it got, the more he noticed the wrongness of it. The long neck. The—

He stopped looking at its face and watched its feet instead. There was a technique to this. Watch the feet, not the face. Feet told you the speed. Feet told you the direction. Feet didn't make you feel like something was wrong with the world.

Three steps. Two. One.

It crossed the limestone line.

Khalid rolled left, came up inside the circle behind it, and squeezed the trigger on the salt bomb before the ghost could turn. The crack of the release echoed in the dead air of the street. Salt burst outward in a white cloud that caught the light from the grey sky above. For a moment, it almost looked beautiful.

The ghost didn't scream. They never screamed. It just stopped. Came apart at the edges. Unraveled like smoke in the wind. In a few seconds, nothing remained but a faint smell—like rain on hot pavement—and the silence of an empty street.

Khalid stood in the limestone circle and let out a slow breath.

He was already thinking about dinner.

The pharmacy had been picked clean years ago. By him, mostly. Back when he first found the building, he spent a week going through every shelf and every drawer. What he hadn't been able to carry, he hid in the walls, behind loose plaster, in the spaces between shelves. Over time, he developed a kind of system to the ruin. This shelf meant canned food. That corner meant tools. The back office, door locked and held shut with an iron bar he dragged six blocks, meant sleep.

He was good at surviving. He knew he was good at it—the kind of good you get after doing something alone for so long that every improvement means staying alive a little longer.

He ate cold beans from a can he opened with a multi-tool while he watched the light change through the gap in the boarded window. The city beyond—the ruins of the city beyond—lay quiet in the specific way it was always quiet now. Like a graveyard.

The Dimming happened before he was born. He had no memory of the world before it, nothing to compare it to. His parents talked about it, sometimes, his mother more than his father. She used to describe grocery stores—the real kind, bright lights and full shelves and thirteen types of cereal—like she described a fairy tale. Her voice carried that mix of wonder and grief that he would only later understand: what loss sounds like after it has been carried for a very long time.

Since then, the Overworld had become a grim, dark, quiet, ghost-riddled landscape.

He didn't let himself think about his parents very often. There was a technique to that, too. You felt the edge of it, and then you stepped back before it pulled you under. Like watching a ghost's feet instead of its face. Necessary.

He pulled the tin from under the floorboard where he kept it.

Two photographs. That made up all that remained of them—two photographs, and whatever he could still remember of their voices, which slipped away a little more with each passing year.

His mother laughed in her photo, caught mid-sentence, looking at something outside the frame. His father looked serious in his, standing very straight, looking directly at the camera with an expression that

Khalid spent years trying to understand and had eventually decided meant *I am here. I am present. I am paying attention.*

He looked at them for exactly as long as he allowed himself to look at them, which was not long.

He put the tin back under the floorboard.

As he brushed the limestone residue off his hands, he heard something outside.

He went still without thinking. Practice made his body react before he could think.

He listened.

The street below was quiet. Too quiet. Not like the graveyard-quiet of before.

He knew this feeling.

Normal ghosts made no sound. That silence was always there.

But this was different. Stronger. He felt it.

He moved to the window and looked through the gap in the boards.

Carver Street stretched below him, empty. The limestone circle sat at the intersection, its edges already blurring. The evening light spread, low and grey, and everything was still. The half-ruined buildings of the city rose into the sky.

He glanced at the hardware store window across the street. Twice this week, he saw someone, a shadow, in the window's dark glass. Both times, when he went back to check, he found nothing.

The temperature dropped.

Not slowly; instantly, like stepping outside in winter. His breath suddenly misted in front of him. His hand snapped to the iron filings at his belt. His fingers felt three salt bombs. He ran the math automatically through his brain: *what do I have? What do I need? What's the gap between them?*

Something moved at the far end of the street.

It was large. Larger than a Normal ghost, which was usually tall. And it moved differently. Normal ghosts drifted. This one moved in a way that felt planned. It turned its head slowly as it scanned the street. Even at this distance, even through the gap in the boards, Khalid felt the attention in that scan like a pressure against his chest.

He stepped back from the window.

His heart started pounding fast, something he hated.

He thought of his three salt bombs and the limestone circle, already smudged. Whatever this thing was, it wasn't a Normal ghost. And the only thing he knew about ghosts like that, was that the usual tricks failed—and he didn't know what worked instead.

He stood in the back of the pharmacy, in the dark, and breathed through his nose.

He waited.

The temperature stayed cold for a long time.

Then, slowly, it began to lift. The pressure in his chest eased. When he finally moved back to the window—carefully, slowly, one eye through the gap—the street was empty. Whatever it was, disappeared.

He stood there for a long time.

He was good at surviving. He knew he was good at it.

But good enough, he was beginning to understand, was not the same as good enough forever.

He found the envelope the next morning.

It sat on the fire escape railing—the fire escape he used as his backup exit. The one he never told anyone about. The one he was sure nobody knew about.

A dark wax seal closed the envelope. It was marked with a simple symbol: a circle with a line through it. Iron and salt. The well-known symbol, if you knew what you were looking at, for ghost hunters.

He stood and looked at it for a long time without touching it.

Then he picked it up, turned it over, and saw his name written in neat, unhurried handwriting.

Khalid.

No last name. No address. Just his name, written by someone who knew exactly where to leave it.

He didn't open it.

He went back inside. Made a careful note of everything he needed to take. Checked his iron stock. Counted his salt bombs. Told himself he wasn't going to open it. Not a chance.

Three hours later, he opened it.

The preceding was an excerpt of One Against the Dimming. You can purchase the full book, from various vendors, here:

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